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GM FOOD HOW SAFE IS IT?

By Amarnath K. Menon

As India prepares to clear the first transgenic food for commercial production, a major storm breaks out over the safety of biotech fruits and vegetables

In India the elongated, deep purple ovoid is considered one of the humblest of vegetables. The Bengalis call it *be-gun* which means a vegetable that has no virtue. But now the lowly brinjal has become the eye of the storm that is forcing you to sit up and take notice as you sit down to eat. For if the Union Government accepts an expert committee report that last week cleared a genetically modified (GM) brinjal for commercial cultivation, it may open the floodgates for a host of such technologically engineered vegetables and fruits that will hit market shelves and eventually your dining table.

At the core of the acrimonious debate is

just how safe these foods are for you and for the environment. The final nod may well remain elusive as the Government is in a bind with consumer and environmental activists joined by politicians of different hues taking sides fired by emotion and, in some cases, informed opinion on issues of safety. "There are strong arguments for and against the introduction of GM brinjal and it will take a lot of time to study them and the final decision would not be taken under the influence of any company or any NGO," says Minister of State for Environment Jairam Ramesh. He plans to hold a series of consultations with scientists, agricultural experts, farmer's organisations, consumer groups and NGOs before finalising his views.

It is not as if genetically engineered